day but for Shroff. He was the moving spirit behind it…We in ICICI have come to regard him as its founding father.' Parekh said that in his student days Shroff's name had somehow got impressed on his subconscious mind though he knew very little of him. 'His background of economics, finance and investment, made a special appeal on me and perhaps, that drew me to these fields for study and career. In this sense I regard A.D. Shroff as my guru…Though I never came to know A.D. Shroff very closely, my selection in ICICI and subsequent promotion as General Manager, were both due in great measure to his powerful support.'[10]

George Woods, who later became the President of the World Bank, was equally fulsome in his praise and referred to the invaluable help rendered by Shroff in the work preparatory to the establishment of ICICI. But within three years of setting up ICICI, Shroff resigned as a Director largely due to irreconcilable differences with G.D. Birla. According to Robert W. Oliver, the biographer of George Woods, 'such a difference of opinion had developed between A.D. Shroff and G.D. Birla that the Board had to be reconstituted.' Shroff never spoke of his differences with Birla. The Birla group owned a sizeable percentage of shares. After some time G.D. Birla retired and his son, K.K. Birla became a Director in 1959. He continued as a Director till 1979 when Jagdish Saxena, Chairman of IDBI, and in that capacity a Director of ICICI, asked him to resign. The Janata government was in power and Birla's head was demanded on the ground that he had continued to support Indira Gandhi even after her defeat in the 1977 general election.[11]

According to Parekh, Kasturbhai Lalbhai also played a major role in shaping ICICI. 'In our formative years, we had to build up relations with the government, build up expertise and build up team spirit among the staff. Kasturbhai helped to mould these.' Remarking about the techniques of project appraisal which were in a nascent stage when ICICI started using them, Parekh observed, 'Project appraisal was a new science and, I am sure, Kasturbhai never got one prepared for the many enterprises started by him. But he knew the essentials. He questioned basic assumptions and had an eye for details. Therefore, our appraisals never became mere exercises on paper.'[12]

H.T. Parekh joins ICICI